NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥6

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K J 4 2
♥ K 5
♦ A K 6
♣ K 9 7 4

♠ 9 7 3
♥ Q J 10 9
♦ 9 4 2
♣ Q 5 3



♠ 10 8 5
♥ A 6 2
♦ Q J 10 7 5
♣ J 6

♠ A Q 6
♥ 8 7 4 3
♦ 8 3
♣ A 10 8 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♦Q

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

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Partner had ♥s, not ♠s. His 2NT bid is invitational, 9-10 points, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

You need one more winner. Although the ♥K is a possibility, there is a real danger of losing 4 tricks in the suit if East holds the ♥A.

A much better idea is to try to establish a ♣ trick, a suit where you hold 8 cards.

You must give up one ♣ trick in order to establish a winner there. It is important that you give up that ♣ trick to East. West is the Danger hand because if he wins a ♣ he might lead through your precarious ♥K. So win the first trick, enter dummy with a ♠ honor, and play a small ♣, finessing the ♣9 when West plays low.

East wins the ♣J, but you win the game. East cannot profitably play ♥s, so he will probably continue with another ♦. But since the ♣Q will now drop under the ♣ A K you have your ninth trick.

This ♣ holding shows an important principle. As long as the suit splits 3-2 you can establish the fourth card as a winner by ducking one trick.

The key is your ability to choose which defender you want to duck the trick into.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q J 9 7
♥ 10 5 4
♦ J 9 6
♣ Q 9 6

♠ K 8 6 2
♥ Q 8
♦ A 8 3
♣ K 5 4 3



♠ A 4 3
♥ K 7 3
♦ K Q 2
♣ A 10 7 2

♠ 10 5
♥ A J 9 6 2
♦ 10 7 5 4
♣ J 8

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♥6

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

You have plenty of points for game; with no 4-4 Major suit fit you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥6.

First big decision. Which ♥ do you play from dummy?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

The Rule of Eleven tells you there are 5 ♥s in West, North and East which are higher than the ♥6. You and dummy hold 4 of them so you can place North with just 1. The missing high cards are ♥ A J 10 9. Elementary, Watson; North must hold the ♥10 because from ♥ A J 10 6, ♥ A 10 9 6 or ♥ J 10 9 6 South would **NOT** have led the ♥6. So your first smart move is to play dummy's ♥Q, which holds the trick. What next?

You need to find one more winner and your best chance is the ♣ suit. You will need a 3-2 split in the suit, but you must establish the ♣ winner without letting North get the lead. North is the Danger Hand because he can play a ♥ throughyour ♥ K 7. Therefore it would be unwise to play ♣A, ♣K, then another ♣ because North is very likely to be the one with 3 ♣s.

Did you get it? Play a small ♣ toward your hand and put on the ♣10 if North plays low. You don't expect the ♣10 to win the trick, it is more of a duck than a finesse. South takes this with his ♣J but he can do you no harm. If he continues with ♥s your ♥K will be a second stopper. If he plays any other suit you will scamper home with your 9 tricks, which of course now include those 3 ♣s.

A duck into the safe hand allowed you to establish the ♣ winner you needed.

But what if North had figured out what you were going to try and played his ♣Q when you led from dummy?

He would have been very, very sorry. You would have had no choice but to win the trick, and when South's ♣J fell on the next trick you would have all 4 ♣ tricks!

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ J 7 5 2
♥ A K 9 8 5
♦ 7 3
♣ 8 3

♠ A Q 10
♥ J 6 2
♦ Q J 10 8
♣ 9 6 4



♠ K 6 4
♥ Q 10 4
♦ 9 6 5
♣ 10 7 5 2

♠ 9 8 3
♥ 7 3
♦ A K 4 2
♣ A K Q J

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦Q

In response to partner's Stayman bid you bid 2♦ to indicate no 4-card Major. Partner now bids 2♥.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you bid 2♦ to indicate no 4-card Major. Partner now bids 2♥.

Partner's bid shows 5♥s, and by inference, 4 ♠s. You hand does not provide an 8-card fit in either Major, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♦Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You need one more winner and without question it must come from the ♥ suit.

Your problem is finding dummy entries, all dummy has is the ♥ A K.

You must find the ♥s split 3-3. You must also duck a ♥ to keep a valuable entry. Win the ♦ and play the ♥7, ducking in dummy.

East will win the ♥ and return a ♦ which you win in your hand. You now play your last ♥ to dummy, and if the suit was originally 3-3 you will win 4 ♥ tricks.

The "brute force" method for establishing dummy's ♥ suit would be to play ♥ A K, then another. If they split 3-3 your last two ♥s would be winners.

Of course you'd look pretty stupid to have those 2 ♥ winners in dummy and no way to reach them.

So you use the duck instead.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ A Q 4 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ 10 7 2 ♣ 10 6 5	
♠ K 10 ♥ A K 7 ♦ Q J 9 5 ♣ A K 8 2	N W E S	♠ J 9 8 7 5 2 ♥ 6 5 2 ♦ K ♣ 9 7 4
	♠ 6 3 ♥ 9 8 4 ♦ A 8 6 4 3 ♣ Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	3♥	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥Q

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With your 6-card Major suit you naturally use a transfer; bid 3♥. Partner responds 3♠.

With your 6-card Major suit you naturally use a transfer; bid 3♥. Partner responds 3♠.

Partner has at least 20 points so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by East.

West plays 4♠. North leads the ♥Q and South plays ♥4.

You win the first trick with your ♥A. By doing this you leave North in the dark about who holds the ♥K. If you had instead won with the ♥K North would have known you held both honors since South would have played the ♥A if he held it.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total =

You have 2 losers to get rid of and the good news is that you can establish 2 ♦ winners pretty easily. So do you start pulling trumps now?

No, stay away from trumps for now. You might have to lose the lead twice in trumps, and the first time they get the lead they will play another ♥ and expose the loser in that suit. Then, the next time they get the lead they will take their ♥ winner. You need to get rid of that ♥ loser **BEFORE** you start on trumps.

Play a small ♦ to the ♦K. South will take this and play another ♥ to your ♥K. Play your ♦Q and discard dummy's ♥ loser. Now you might just as well ruff that ♥ in dummy, (with the ♠7 to be safe), and play trumps from that side. It turns out that North has both high trumps but you don't care because dummy's ♣ loser can be dumped on your ♦J.

The ♦A was a "fast" loser which you couldn't avoid. But the ♥ loser was a "slow" loser. Slow losers can sometimes be discarded, but you may have to do so before you lose the lead too many times.

Did you notice that if the opening lead had been a ♣ instead of a ♥ you would have used the same technique?